

Your baby's amazing journey

Play and playfulness form the basis of your baby's development during the first months of her life. Why is play so important? Your baby has arrived primed to learn. Her brain is developing at the fastest rate she'll ever experience and it's through play that she'll soak up most of the information she needs to make sense of her world. When you play with your baby you offer her opportunities to explore, experiment, and experience. As you play together, and perhaps without consciously realizing it, you're fueling her senses and providing essential stimulation for her brain development.

Over the coming year, as your play activities together change and evolve, you'll be rewarded by advances in your baby's speech and language, her knowledge of the world around her, and her awareness of her body and how to control it. You'll also notice her relationships with others strengthen and her bond with you deepening.

This chart shows some of the major developmental milestones your baby will reach by 18 months. It's useful to remember, though, that babies naturally develop at different rates and your baby may reach her milestones a little earlier or later than other babies.

The developmental milestones listed here are approximate, but if your baby's progress is starting to concern you, seek advice from your pediatrician. In most cases you'll be reassured that she's doing fine or, for a few infants, early difficulties may be picked up and practical help offered.

